

Super Troupers

Well over a century old, this theatre group juggles domestic chores and stage performances. Married daughters don't leave; their husbands join the act.



MAGIC IS AN ESSENTIAL PART OF THE SURABHI GROUP'S REPERTOIRE

By Nirmala Ravindran

The youngest performer is a 20-day-old who has performed the role of infant Krishna while his immediate senior, 18-month-old Hrushithesh, has done over 150 performances. Welcome to Surabhi Theatre, where life is an extension of theatre. Back stage, women help each other with their make-up and costumes even as they rock their children to sleep. They continue with household chores even as the play goes on. "At home, we continue cooking between the scenes, because the troupe needs to eat after the show," says a lead actor, essaying the role of Krishna for the epic play *Maya Bazaar*. The 120-year-old theatre group, "is married to this profession and everyone in this family exists only for theatre," says the head of the troupe Nageswara Rao, also known as Bapji. The family, comprising more than 65 members, does not send off its daughters in marriage, rather the sons-in-law join the group. "We can't afford to lose trained actresses, nor do the girls wish to discontinue," says a cast member.

What started off in a tiny hamlet near Ravchoti, in Kadapa district, thanks to the efforts of Vanaras Govinda

Rao, a Maharashtra immigrant with the staging of an adaptation of *Keechakavadha* has survived changing preferences of audiences by reinventing itself. Historical dramas have been refashioned to suit present day tastes.

The late B.V. Karanth showcased Surabhi's work across the country. "The special effects are unheard of. I have never seen anything like this live on stage," says Bangalore adman Sunil Joshi, after watching *Maya Bazaar* where sets change in a flicker and laddoos disappear into the mouth of Ghatotkach. Theatre scholar V. Subba Rao agrees, "I've watched several plays and their tricks and magic are unmatched." Cobras with fully-spread hoods, arrows that create rain and fire on stage, and Sasirekha flying across on a swan. In the age of digital printing, Surabhi still uses painstakingly-created hand painted backdrops. Despite drawing full houses, Surabhi can barely make ends meet. "Our shows work very well, but we are not able to meet production costs," says Bapji. Looking at the magic that its shows create, the talented group will surely come up with innovative solutions for its survival. Now watch that laddoo disappear! ■